

Discipline Yourself So No One Else Has To: Discipline Should Be Fair, Featuring Teela Jackson

Coach Pat Summitt

“As a leader, you cannot develop discipline in others if you don’t have self-discipline. It starts at the top. You have to demonstrate that no staff member, no employee, no star player, is above the rules. I don’t ask anything of our players that I haven’t asked of myself.”

Teela Jackson, Vice President, HR

Like all great coaches, business managers, and leaders, Pat Summitt did not believe you should treat everyone exactly the same. Some of her players needed to be pushed and challenged. Some thrived on more praise. Others just needed an occasional pat on the back or for someone to simply just give them the ball and get out of their way. Still others required a very pointed stare -- you know, Pat’s famous stare.

Whether you are a coach or a business leader, discipline, according to Pat, must be consistent, firm, and fair. To her mind, there is no faster way to destroy synergy and respect on a team or in an organization than to administer discipline unequally. There can be no playing favorites. She was clearly an equal opportunity disciplinarian. The rules must be fair and aimed at solving problems or potential problems before they materialize, and the consequences for breaking those rules must be clear, consistent, and firm.

Disciplinary measures should not be compromised.

Coach Pat Summitt

“Be fair. The fewer rules you have, the fewer rules will be broken.”

Teela Jackson, Vice President, HR

Establishing discipline will be a lot easier if you don’t burden people with a lot of silly, minor regulations. All you need is a handful of fair ones that you are prepared to enforce, and when people participate in setting their own goals, standards, and regulations, they tend to be more cooperative.

Pat continued this thought with, “If all you ever do is crack down on people, they won’t stay in your program or your business. They’ll leave. Why would you stay someplace if all it offered was punishment? You wouldn’t. Similarly, if all you do is punish yourself, chances are you won’t maintain your training regimen or work regimen. You’ll quit on it. If you are fair with yourself, you stand a better chance of maintaining your self-discipline.”

